



Taking advantage

There are some living things that just can't help taking advantage of others. They often get away with it, but crime doesn't always pay...

Six victims speak out about the shocking

I didn't know he was living there, but I had a STRANGE FEELING that I was eating for two.

VICTIM
Cow

I'd only gone out for a few hours but when I came back HE'D MOVED IN and wouldn't leave.

VICTIM
Gopher tortoise

CRIMINAL
Burrowing owl

That penguin STOLE THE FOOD right out of my mouth—and in broad daylight, too!

VICTIM
Pelican

CRIMINAL
Galápagos penguin

PARASITES

Parasites are plants or animals that live in or on another species. They feed directly from them, absorbing nutrients that they wouldn't be able to obtain or make for themselves. Some parasites target only a single species. Others have a complex life cycle where they change hosts as they move from eggs and larvae to adults. Tapeworms live in the guts of animals, feeding on partly digested food. They also live in humans.

SQUATTERS

It takes a lot of effort to build the perfect home so if you can find one that's ready to move into, all the better. Burrowing animals, such as aardvarks or prairie dogs may take days to dig out tunnels underground. If they leave for any length of time an opportunist may sneak in and take it over. Burrowing owls are capable of building their own burrows but will take advantage of a gopher tortoise's excavations if they can.

THIEVES AND MUGGERS

Why spend hours searching for food when you can steal it from someone else? Many animals take advantage of their size, strength, or sheer cunning to make another give up its dinner. Some will even rob members of their own species. Galápagos penguins often chase pelicans and force them to open their beaks rather than hunt for their own fish. However, they risk injury if their victim objects.